Reading 1.2B Who Owns the World Fleet

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Slide 4 of Lecture 1.2 shows a world map of who controls the merchant fleet. This reading explains it. It is extended reading: it is **not part of the Evaluation Test**.

Beneficial owner. UNCTAD counts each ship under the economy where the company with the main commercial responsibility for it is located: the company that decides what the ship does and takes its profit or loss. That is not the flag the ship flies, and not always the one-ship company named on its registration papers, which is usually a shell set up in Liberia, the Marshall Islands or Panama.

The data. UNCTADstat, data from Clarksons Research, ships of 1,000 GT and above, 1 January 2026, in deadweight tonnes (dwt). Deadweight measures what a ship can lift, so it gives most weight to bulk carriers and tankers; a ranking in TEU or in value would look different.

The big picture. Companies in Asia own 56 % of the world's carrying capacity, companies in Europe 34 % and companies in North America 4 %. Three economies stand far ahead of the rest: Greece, China and Japan. Hong Kong is counted separately from China; together they would come first.

The top owners at a glance

Rank	Economy	Million dwt	What its owners mainly own
1	Greece	397	Bulk carriers, tankers, LNG carriers; chartered out
2	China	377	All types; state groups and leasing houses
3	Japan	243	Bulk carriers, gas carriers, car carriers
4	Singapore	182	Tankers, bulk, containers; a hub for foreign owners
5	Hong Kong	122.8	Bulk carriers, containers; Chinese leasing arms
6	South Korea	99.2	Bulk, tankers, gas carriers, containers

Rank	Economy	Million dwt	What its owners mainly own
7	Germany	69.0	Container ships, multipurpose ships
8	Taiwan	66.2	Container ships of its own lines; bulk
9	United Kingdom	61.1	Mixed; London as a shipping centre
10	United Arab Emirates	59.6	Tankers, offshore; Dubai as a hub
11–14	Norway, Turkey, United States, Denmark	45 to 50 each	

Source: UNCTADstat, beneficial ownership, 1 January 2026. The descriptions in the last column are a general guide, not UNCTAD data.

The top ten, one by one

1 Greece: the tramp owners

Greece has no giant shipping line, yet its owners control the largest fleet in the world: nearly 5,800 ships, over 19 % of world tonnage and 61 % of the fleet controlled by EU companies (Union of Greek Shipowners, May 2026). Three things explain it. First, **the measure**: dwt rewards bulk carriers and tankers, and that is where Greek owners are. Second, **the business model**: they are tramp owners and tonnage providers (slide 3, rows 2 and 3). They own the ships and charter them to oil majors, miners, traders and shipping lines; Costamare and Danaos, both container tonnage providers, are Greek. Third, **many companies**: the fleet is spread over several hundred mostly family firms, so no Greek name tops the company ranking on slide 4, but together they top the country map. Behind it lie a seafaring tradition from islands such as Chios, Andros and Kasos, the cheap Liberty ships bought after 1945, a habit of buying ships in a slump and selling in a boom, a tonnage tax regime and a dense network of brokers and banks between Piraeus and London. Most Greek-owned ships fly the flags of Liberia, the Marshall Islands or Malta, not Greece.

2 China: state groups and leasing houses

China's fleet has grown fastest of all since 2000. Much of it sits in two state groups, **COSCO Shipping** (the largest shipowner of all types, and the fourth container line) and **China Merchants**, which carry the country's imports of oil, ore, coal and grain and its container exports. The second pillar is **finance**: leasing arms of Chinese banks, such as Bocom, ICBC and CMB Financial Leasing, buy ships and charter them back to operators all

over the world (sale and leaseback, slide 3). That makes a lessor the third-largest shipowner on slide 4. Chinese yards build most of these ships. Counted together with Hong Kong, China would be first.

3 Japan: trading houses and the owners of Imabari

Japanese owners control about 12 % of world dwt (BIMCO, 2025) and the world's largest fleet of gas carriers. Two groups matter. The big Tokyo operators, **NYK, MOL and K Line**, carry Japan's energy and raw material imports on long contracts and run car carriers; since 2018 their container business has been merged into one line, ONE. The second group are the family owners around **Imabari** in Ehime prefecture, about a hundred firms with roughly a third of the Japanese fleet (Shoei Kisen, Nissen Kaiun and others). They build at Japanese yards, are financed by regional banks, and charter the ships to Japanese and foreign operators; Shoei Kisen is the second-largest container tonnage provider (slide 4). Many Japanese-owned ships fly the Panama flag.

4 Singapore: the hub

Singapore's fleet is not only Singaporean. Low taxes for shipping companies, a large ship register, banks, insurers and the world's largest bunkering port have drawn owners and managers from abroad to base their companies there; Eastern Pacific Shipping and BW Group are examples. Its owners cover tankers, bulk carriers and container ships, and many ships also fly the Singapore flag.

5 Hong Kong: China's international face

Hong Kong is counted separately. Its owners include Pacific Basin (bulk carriers), OOCL (container line, part of COSCO since 2018) and old family firms; many Chinese leasing companies hold their ships through Hong Kong companies, and the Hong Kong register is one of the largest in the world.

6 South Korea: cargo owners and yards

Korean owners work closely with the country's energy importers and steel makers, often on long contracts for bulk carriers, tankers and gas carriers, and with Korean yards, which build much of the world's LNG fleet. HMM is the national container line; Pan Ocean and Sinokor are large bulk and container owners.

7 Germany: the tonnage providers that shrank

Twenty years ago German owners led the world in container ships chartered to shipping lines. Many were financed by **KG funds**, partnerships of private investors with tax advantages, one fund per ship. After the 2008 crisis charter rates fell, the funds failed and

the banks withdrew; Seaspan, Shoei Kisen and Costamare took over the top places (Alphaliner). What remains is Hapag-Lloyd, a strong group of ship managers and a smaller fleet of container and multipurpose ships, now growing again.

8 Taiwan: container lines

Taiwan is the one economy in the top ten whose tonnage is led by its own container lines: **Evergreen, Yang Ming and Wan Hai**, all among the world's top ten lines. Here the owner and the operator are the same company.

9 United Kingdom: London

The UK owns a mixed fleet, but its weight in shipping is larger than its tonnage: London is the centre for ship broking, marine insurance, P&I clubs, ship finance and maritime law. Most shipbuilding contracts and charter parties are written under English law and settled by arbitration in London, and several large owners run their business from there, such as Zodiac Maritime.

10 United Arab Emirates: the new hub

The UAE's fleet has grown quickly, with state groups such as ADNOC Logistics and Services and owners attracted to Dubai's free zones. Part of the growth is less transparent: analysts have found that many of the older tankers carrying Russian oil after the 2022 sanctions belong to newly formed companies registered in the UAE (CREA, 2023). Ownership data can show where companies are, but not always who really stands behind them.

The next tier, and who is missing

Norway, Turkey, the United States and Denmark follow with 45 to 50 million dwt each. Norway is strong in gas carriers, car carriers and offshore vessels; Turkey's owners are mostly family firms in bulk carriers and small tankers; US owners hold most of their fleet under foreign flags, often the Marshall Islands, while the US-flag fleet is small; Denmark is home to Maersk, which charters a large part of its container fleet, and to tanker and bulk operators. Further down come Indonesia, India, France (CMA CGM), Vietnam, Iran, the Netherlands and Russia.

Not on the map. Some well-known shipping centres have no figure in the source used for slide 4 and appear grey: **Switzerland**, home of MSC, the largest container line, and **Bermuda, Cyprus and Monaco**, where many owners and managers are based. Their fleets are real; they are simply not shown, so read the map as a guide, not a complete count.

Owner, flag and manager: three different maps

The same ship can belong to three countries at once:

- **Owner** (this reading): where the company that controls and profits from the ship sits. A Greek family in Athens.
- **Flag**: the state where the ship is registered, whose laws apply on board and which issues its statutory certificates. Liberia, the Marshall Islands and Panama, the open registers, carry far more ships than their owners' countries.
- **Manager**: the company that crews and maintains it under the ISM Code (slide 3). Often in Cyprus, Singapore, Hong Kong or India.

So a map of flags would show Liberia, Panama and the Marshall Islands at the top, and a map of owners shows Greece, China and Japan.

Why it matters to the ship designer

The country of the owner says a lot about the kind of buyer at the yard. A Greek tramp owner or a German tonnage provider wants a standard ship that many charterers will accept and that can be resold; a Japanese or Korean owner working on a long contract with a cargo owner can specify the ship closely around that trade; a Chinese leasing house cares above all that the ship keeps its value as security; a Taiwanese container line designs around its own network. Same ship type, different requirements.

Questions to think about

1. Why does Greece lead in dwt but not in TEU? What would a ranking by TEU look like?
2. Hong Kong is counted apart from China. Would you combine them? What changes?
3. Which kind of owner on this list would most likely order the two Azores ships of the project, and why?
4. Why might a ship owned in Greece, managed in Cyprus and flagged in Liberia still be built to Chinese or Korean yard standards?

Sources

- UNCTADstat Data Insights: maritime transport, fleet ownership, 2026
- Orbis, shipbuilding and fleet ownership by country, 2026, from UNCTADstat
- Union of Greek Shipowners, Annual Report 2025–2026 press release, 26 May 2026
- BIMCO via Baird Maritime: Japan's owners control 12 % of the fleet, 29 April 2025
- Splash247, Alphaliner: Germany's decline as a boxship tonnage provider

- Shipping Telegraph, CREA: UAE and Russia the biggest registered owners of shadow tankers, 28 September 2023

Figures move every year; check a source before quoting a number.